

The Hansard

A WEEKLY DIGEST OF THE PROCEEDINGS OF THE PARLIAMENT OF THE UNITED KINGDOM

The largest maternity review in NHS history

The gravest business of the week was a report the House could barely bear to read. On 24 June the Health and Social Care Secretary, James Murray, responded to Donna Ockenden’s review of maternity services at Nottingham University Hospitals — “the largest into a maternity service in the history of the NHS,” covering thirteen years, 2,536 affected families and 838 staff — with an apology, an extension of Martha’s rule to all maternity and neonatal settings, and a vow that its recommendations

would not, this time, gather dust. The statement was repeated in the Lords on 29 June, and on 30 June Murray returned with a second, on Baroness Amos’s national maternity investigation and the first-ever maternity commissioner it will create. Around that reckoning the Chamber turned to trade, defence and borders: a steel trade measure taking effect on 1 July and Jim Allister’s urgent question on how it lands in Northern Ireland; the Defence Investment Plan, the week’s most-contributed statement; an asylum-

accommodation statement and the Immigration and Asylum Bill’s second reading. The division bell rang just four times, all on the Monday, the sharpest a customs-tariff vote at 323 to 160. And of 2,157 written questions from 228 members, two clusters told opposite stories — a genuinely House-wide worry about the heatwave, and a concentrated press of 41 questions on asylum from just five members, the subject of our feature.

THE DIVISIONS, CLOSEST FIRST

Customs (Tariff) Regulations
323 160
Carried by 163 on 24 June

Climate Change Act, Aviation and Shipping
329 94
Carried by 235 on 24 June

Climate Change Act, Credit Limit
330 93
Carried by 237 on 24 June

Carbon Budget Order
332 94
Carried by 238 on 24 June



THE MOST-ASKED SUBJECTS
12 Natural History: GCSE · 11 Social Security Benefits: Debts · 10 Defence: Finance · 9 Energy: Housing · 8 Asylum: Housing · 8 Calder Valley Line: Rolling Stock · 8 Iron and Steel: Import Duties · 8 Schools: Temperature · 7 Apprentices: Accountancy · 7 Asylum and Immigration: Appeals

THE FEATURE

The asylum press: forty-one questions, five members

The single biggest written-question theme of the week was not, as it usually is, a broad concern raised by many members from many directions. It was a concentrated press: 41 questions on asylum accommodation, appeals and cost, tabled by just five members — and dominated by two. Andrew Snowden (Conservative) tabled sixteen and Rupert Lowe (Restore Britain) fifteen, with Nick Timothy (Conservative) adding a further seven forensic questions on tribunal appeals; Sarah Pochin (Reform UK) tabled two and Jim Dickson (Labour) one. Set that against the heat-warning cluster the same week — 39 questions from twelve different members — and the shape is unmistakable: this was a coordinated right-of-centre and insurgent line of attack, not a House-wide alarm. The subjects trace the enforcement-and-cost frame precisely. Snowden pressed on houses in multiple occupation and their licences, on the comparative cost of hotels against dispersed accommodation, on crime data for asylum sites, and on the twenty hotels the Government had just announced for closure. Lowe pursued the Crowborough training-camp site — its entry and exit controls, its activities — the average total cost to the public purse per asylum seeker, and the handling of refused claims. Timothy asked only the Justice Secretary, and only about numbers: hearings listed, adjourned and disposed of in the First-tier and Upper Tribunals of the Immigration and Asylum Chamber. Pochin wanted the annual cost of accommodation contracts and a hotel count by local authority. Only Dickson, from the Government benches, asked in a different key — whether the Home Office would publish figures on unaccompanied asylum-seeking children. One subject, then, but two Parliaments: the many who worry about a heat-wave, and the few who have made asylum their standing brief.

A SAMPLE OF THE WEEK’S QUESTIONS

Iron and Steel: Import Duties · Jess Brown-Fuller, Liberal Democrat

What assessment he has made of the potential impact of the tariff measures proposed in the UK Steel Strategy on the supply of unfabricated steel products and the potential subsequent downstream impact on the construction industry.

THE ANSWER The Government took into account a range of different factors alongside extensive engagement with producers and downstream users to inform the design of the trade measure. This included considerations around the scale of UK demand, production, capacity and recent trade levels.

THE RECORD

Every figure checked against the official Parliament record. Compiled from the Official Report, the written question record and the division lists, and rendered to one sheet for the week.